each other down with flannels of giddy joy and the talc of intimacy. Two memsahibs, also his lovers, would join them.'[57]

Such rumours quickly began to sour the initially good relations between the people of Kabul and the occupying army. Kabul already had a discreet red-light district in the quarter occupied by Indian musicians and dancers close to the walls of the Bala Hisar. But there were not nearly enough Indian *rundis* around to cope with the demand created by the garrison of 4,500 sepoys and 15,500 camp followers, and a growing number of Afghan women seem to have made themselves available for a short but profitable ride into the cantonment. Indeed this became so common that the British began to compose rhymes about the easy availability of Afghan women:

> A Kabul wife under burkha cover,
> Was never known without a lover.[58]

Mohammad Husain Herati wrote:

> It was reported to His Majesty by well-wishers that there was a thriving market in female prostitutes who were publicly, day and night, carried on horseback into the English camp. These prostitutes wore fine clothes and jewellery and make-up, fearlessly came in and out unchallenged, so that one could not tell if they were of noble lineage or common sluts – all this undermined public morality and the very basis of the state. It was the hypocrites of the Barakzai faction who first showed the way to this corruption and then blamed His Majesty, hoping thereby to arouse the moral indignation of simple people. His Majesty raised the matter with Macnaghten, who had little experience of the treachery and baseness of these people and only answered: 'If we stop the soldiers having sex, the poor boys will fall quite ill!' His Majesty answered: 'That may well be true; however, in this kingdom at least, it would be better to discipline the soldiers and to respect the outward appearance of morality!'[59]

Fayz Mohammad wrote in the later *Siraj ul-Tawarikh* that this growing slight to Afghan honour was the biggest cause of the alienation of the Afghans from their new government.

> The Shah's well-wishers, who were adherents of the Shar'ia of the Prophet and knew that this disgraceful business ripped the veil of religious honour . . . complained to the Shah who told Macnaghten, 'Better that you should stop the traffic in this market's goods by punishment. Otherwise, this tree of wickedness is going to bear unwholesome fruit.' But Sir William Macnaghten did not heed the Shah's words and soon forgot all about them . . . Until then it was still not generally known that when it came to affairs of state and matters affecting the army the Shah had no influence. Now the Barakzais went about revealing the way things really stood saying, 'The Shah is Shah in name only and has no hand in state matters.' Moreover, for their own purposes, they would play up the role of the English. Dangerously flirting with the fire of